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Motivation Handoff Guide

Use this guide when you need to describe **goals, non-goals, risks, assumptions, trade-offs, and open governance questions**.

This guide is about **why** the system exists and what strategic forces shape it.

KNOWLEDGE AREA

This guide helps with **goals, risks, assumptions, and trade-offs**. Technically, it covers **strategic intent, risk, and assumption management**.

Guide family map

Where this guide sits in the full Blueprint Handoff Atlas family.

ROOT & CROSS-CUTTING

Handoff Atlas | Blueprint Bundle | Metamodel Vocabulary | Migrations

DESIGN

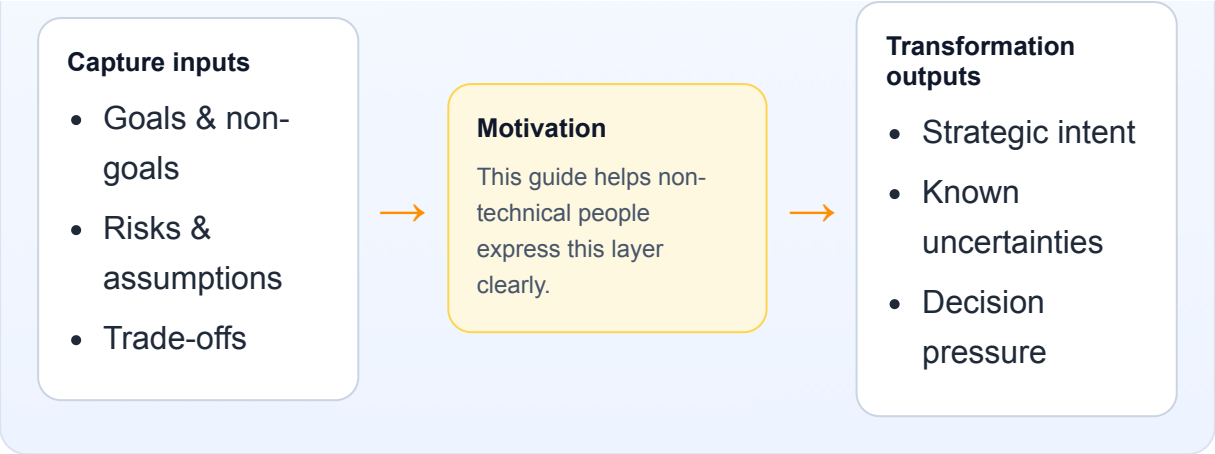
Architecture | Concepts | Domain | Dynamics | Infrastructure | Interactions | Models | Quality | Rules | Story

GOVERNANCE

Capability | Decisions | **Motivation** | Organization | Roadmap | Leverage | Test Cases | Value Stream

Capture → focus → transformation

What to gather first, what this layer focuses on, and what a modeler or AI agent can produce from it.



Main entities in this guide

- **Goal** - an outcome the system or organization is trying to achieve.
- **Non Goal** - something intentionally out of scope, even if it sounds nearby.
- **Risk** - a meaningful threat to the goal or delivery outcome.
- **Assumption** - something believed true and relied on, but not guaranteed.
- **Trade Off** - a conscious balance between competing goods or constraints.
- **Inquiry** - an open question that still needs an answer.
    - Often confused with: a **Decision**. Motivation captures intent, uncertainty, and tension; decisions capture chosen direction.

What belongs here

- goals and desired outcomes
- non-goals and boundaries
- risks and threats
- assumptions that may prove wrong
- trade-offs between competing concerns
- unresolved strategic questions

What does not belong here

- detailed process steps
- final decisions without their surrounding motivation
- raw metrics without a strategic purpose

Core things to capture

- what is being aimed for
- what is intentionally out of scope

- what could go wrong
- what is being assumed
- what tension exists between important concerns

Core relationships to capture

- goal -> quality measure or capability supported
- risk -> goal threatened
- assumption -> consequence if false
- trade-off -> concerns being balanced
- inquiry -> decision or clarification needed

Modus operandi

Use motivation to make implicit reasoning visible:

1. state the goals clearly
2. name what is out of scope
3. identify risks and assumptions
4. capture tensions and trade-offs
5. record unresolved questions that block good decisions

Prompt set

- what are we trying to achieve?
- what are we explicitly not trying to do?
- what could threaten the goal?
- what are we assuming is true?
- what tensions do we accept consciously?

Free-text intake template

- **Goal / non-goal / risk / assumption / trade-off / inquiry:**
- **Statement:**
- **Why it matters:**
- **What it affects:**
- **Consequence if ignored or false:**

Worked example

- Goal: customers can submit return requests without contacting support

- Risk: inconsistent return decisions create fairness and cost concerns
- Assumption: policy rules capture return eligibility well enough to decide quickly
- Trade-off: faster self-service returns vs tighter manual control

Layer-specific handoff guidance

For motivation, the handoff should make **strategic pressure visible**.

The receiver should be able to distinguish:

- goals from non-goals
- risks from assumptions
- trade-offs from decisions

If the handoff mixes these categories together, later design and governance work will blur.

How this becomes YAML

A technical modeler or AI agent can transform this into motivation entries that later connect to decisions, quality measures, and capabilities.

Common mistakes

- writing vague goals with no clear intent
- hiding assumptions inside decision text
- omitting non-goals
- listing risks without saying what they threaten